

A Policy Agenda for Yonkers

A tagline and five practical policies for every issue residents raised on the City of Yonkers' social media, 2021 – 2026

Fourteen issues, ranked by how often residents raised them. Each carries a tagline, a line in a resident's own words, and five policies — some deliverable inside a year, some requiring a capital plan and a term of office. Policies are drafted from the specific streets, fees, parks and rules residents named, not from a generic municipal template.

These are proposals, not costed commitments. Nothing here has been through legal review, budget scoring, or a check against what the city is already doing. Treat it as an agenda to argue with.

The taglines at a glance

#	Issue	Tagline	Share
1	Snow, Flooding & Storm Response	Plow Every Street, Not Just the Main Ones	17.3%
2	City Responsiveness & Accountability	Every Complaint Gets a Number	13.7%
3	Taxes & Cost of Living	End the Yonkers Surcharge	10.3%
4	Schools & Education	Build Schools, Not Just Buildings	9.5%
5	Parking	No Ticket Without a Sweep	8.4%
6	Trash, Sanitation & Illegal Dumping	Clean Streets, Every Block	7.9%
7	Jobs, Hiring & Local Economy	Yonkers Jobs for Yonkers Residents	6.5%
8	Roads & Potholes	Pave It, Don't Patch It	6.4%
9	Crime & Public Safety	Guns Off Our Blocks	6.1%
10	Housing & Overdevelopment	Affordable Means Affordable Here	5.7%
11	Parks & Public Spaces	Every Park Playable	2.9%
12	Homelessness & Quality of Life	A Door for Everyone	2.5%
13	Street Lighting & Infrastructure	Light Every Corner	1.8%
14	Traffic, Speeding & Reckless Driving	Slow the Streets Down	1.0%

1

Snow, Flooding & Storm Response

155 complaints · 17.3% of all complaints

“Plow Every Street, Not Just the Main Ones”

Resident: “Side streets are icy, dangerous, and barely passable... Yonkers has many many hills.”

Term	Policy
SHORT	Pre-treat the hills before the first flake Publish a named list of steep-grade streets that get brined ahead of every forecast storm, and post completion times so residents can see it happened.
SHORT	Publish a live plow map GPS on every plow, feeding a public map showing when each street was last cleared. This ends the argument about whether a street was skipped.
SHORT	Never ticket a street the city hasn't cleaned Suspend alternate-side enforcement on any block that has not yet been plowed curb to curb, and void tickets issued on uncleaned streets automatically.
LONG	Buy snow melters for the dense corridors Residents proposed this directly. Melters let crews remove snow from narrow streets with nowhere to pile it, instead of pushing it into parked cars and crosswalks.
LONG	Rebuild drainage where flooding repeats Map every block that floods more than once in three years and put catch-basin and storm-sewer upgrades on a funded, published schedule.

2

City Responsiveness & Accountability

123 complaints · 13.7% of all complaints

“Every Complaint Gets a Number”

Resident: “Financial accountability. What does the city do with the funds they grab from tax payers?”

Term	Policy
SHORT	A real 311 with a tracking number Every report gets a case number, an owner, and a status the resident can check without calling back.
SHORT	Publish response times by department and district A monthly scorecard showing how long each department takes to close cases, broken out by neighbourhood so no district is quietly served last.
SHORT	Answer the channels the city actually posts on Staff the comment threads. A large share of these complaints are questions the city never answered in the place they were asked.
LONG	Put the checkbook online A searchable register of contracts, vendors and payments over a set threshold, updated monthly. The corruption complaints here are mostly complaints about not being able to see anything.
LONG	Independent inspector general An office outside the mayor's control, with subpoena power and published findings, to investigate procurement and hiring.

3

Taxes & Cost of Living

92 complaints · 10.3% of all complaints

“End the Yonkers Surcharge”*Resident: “When will the income tax surcharge be eliminated? You are bankrupting the citizens of Yonkers.”*

Term	Policy
SHORT	Publish a plain-language tax receipt Every property owner gets a one-page breakdown of where their money went, by service, each year.
SHORT	Expand and auto-enrol senior and veteran exemptions Most people who qualify never apply. Use records the city already holds to enrol them and backdate the relief.
LONG	Phase out the resident income tax surcharge Set a multi-year schedule to retire the surcharge, funded by growth in the commercial tax base rather than a service cut.
LONG	Grow the commercial base deliberately Tie development approvals to net new commercial ratables, so new buildings widen the tax base instead of shifting the burden onto existing homeowners.
LONG	Independent reassessment on a fixed cycle Regular, transparent reassessment stops the slow drift that leaves long-time owners paying a premium over recent buyers.

4

Schools & Education

85 complaints · 9.5% of all complaints

“Build Schools, Not Just Buildings”*Resident: “It is great more housing is being built, but where are the children going to go to school?”*

Term	Policy
SHORT	Publish a school-capacity map beside every project No residential approval moves without the enrolment impact for the receiving schools printed in the public file.
SHORT	Get the trailers out of use first Fund and publish a dated plan to retire portable classrooms, starting with the most overcrowded schools.
LONG	A school-impact contribution on large residential projects Developments above a unit threshold contribute to classroom capacity in the district they fill.
LONG	A capital plan that tracks the housing pipeline Tie the school construction schedule to approved units, so capacity arrives with the residents rather than a decade later.
LONG	Competitive teacher pay and retention Yonkers competes with wealthier Westchester districts for the same teachers. Pay parity is the precondition for everything else on this list.

5 Parking

75 complaints · 8.4% of all complaints

“No Ticket Without a Sweep”

Resident: “How can alternate side be enforced when there is nowhere to park on many streets?”

Term	Policy
SHORT	Enforcement follows the sweeper, not the calendar Alternate-side tickets are only valid where cleaning actually happened that day. This is the single most repeated grievance in the data.
SHORT	Fix the meter contradiction When alternate-side is suspended for snow, suspend meter enforcement on the same blocks instead of charging for spaces nobody can reach.
SHORT	Notice before the ticket Push rule changes to text and email the evening before, and void tickets from any change announced with less than 12 hours' notice.
LONG	Residential permit parking in the squeezed neighbourhoods Where housing density outran the curb, permits give residents a realistic chance at a space near home.
LONG	Shared municipal garages in the dense corridors Build or lease structured parking so overnight demand comes off streets that cannot be cleaned while full.

6 Trash, Sanitation & Illegal Dumping

71 complaints · 7.9% of all complaints

“Clean Streets, Every Block”

Resident: “Every road littered with trash, every exit ramp to any thruway, parkway or highway looks a wreck.”

Term	Policy
SHORT	Free bulk pickup on demand Most illegal dumping is mattresses and furniture. Make legal disposal easier and free to schedule, and the pile-ups fall.
SHORT	Cameras and real fines at the known dumping sites Residents can already name the spots. Enforce there first and publish the results.
SHORT	Adopt the ramps and trailheads A standing clean-up schedule for highway ramps and the Old Croton Aqueduct trail, which residents raise repeatedly and which fall between agency responsibilities.
LONG	Hold large buildings to the same rules as homeowners Summonses for apartment buildings that mix recycling and refuse, with escalating penalties for repeat offenders.
LONG	Containerised collection on the dense corridors Move from loose bags to shared containers on the busiest streets, which cuts both litter and the rat population.

7

Jobs, Hiring & Local Economy

58 complaints · 6.5% of all complaints

“Yonkers Jobs for Yonkers Residents”

Resident: “I have a union card and can't find no work... they only hire their own family and friends.”

Term	Policy
SHORT	Post every city job in one public place One portal, every opening, with closing dates and the number of applicants. The perception of a closed shop is fed by invisibility.
SHORT	Publish hiring outcomes For each posting, report applicants, interviews and hires by residency. Transparency is the cheapest answer to patronage complaints.
LONG	Local hire requirements on subsidised projects Any project taking a tax abatement commits to a Yonkers residency share for construction and permanent jobs, with clawbacks if missed.
LONG	Apprenticeships tied to the capital programme Route residents into the trades through the city's own paving, school and sewer work.
LONG	Storefront strategy for the commercial strips Targeted help for small business on the corridors residents name, rather than incentives concentrated on the waterfront.

8

Roads & Potholes

57 complaints · 6.4% of all complaints

“Pave It, Don't Patch It”

Resident: “Patching a road isn't considered fixing it.”

Term	Policy
SHORT	Publish the paving list before the season Every street scheduled for the year, posted in advance, with completion dates marked off as work finishes.
SHORT	Guaranteed pothole turnaround A published deadline from report to repair, with the count of missed deadlines reported monthly.
SHORT	Make utilities restore full width Require full-width repaving after utility cuts instead of the trench patches that fail within a winter.
LONG	A funded multi-year resurfacing programme Rank every street by condition and fund a rolling schedule, so reconstruction replaces perpetual patching.
LONG	Fix the crossings while you pave Rebuild crosswalks, curb ramps and sidewalks as part of each paving job, including the arterials residents call unsafe to cross on foot.

9

Crime & Public Safety

55 complaints · 6.1% of all complaints

“Guns Off Our Blocks”*Resident: “A 15-year-old with a gun. How does someone that young get their hands on one?”*

Term	Policy
SHORT	Focused deterrence on the small number driving violence Concentrate outreach and enforcement on the individuals and blocks that account for most shootings, rather than broad sweeps.
SHORT	Fund credible-messenger violence interruption Trained community workers who can defuse retaliation before it becomes the next shooting.
SHORT	Trace every recovered firearm and publish the results Show residents where guns are actually coming from, which is the question they keep asking.
LONG	Year-round paid youth employment The comments tie youth violence to having nothing to do. Steady paid work and late-night programming is the long-term answer.
LONG	Beat officers who stay on the same blocks Consistent assignment so officers and residents know each other, instead of rotating faces after every incident.

10

Housing & Overdevelopment

51 complaints · 5.7% of all complaints

“Affordable Means Affordable Here”*Resident: “Hudson Piers requires tenants to make 66 times the income for affordable housing. What a joke.”*

Term	Policy
SHORT	Set affordability to Yonkers incomes Peg income limits to the local median rather than a regional figure that prices out the residents the units are meant for.
SHORT	Publish every project's affordable split Unit counts, rent levels and income requirements posted plainly at approval. Residents did this arithmetic themselves - 225 market to 25 affordable - and were angry about what they found.
SHORT	One application for every affordable unit in the city A single waiting list and portal instead of per-building lotteries that reward whoever hears first.
LONG	Raise the mandatory affordable share on upzoned sites If the city grants the density, the public gets more than a token set-aside.
LONG	Permanent affordability and anti-harassment enforcement Long deed restrictions so units cannot convert to market rate, with a funded office to enforce against landlord harassment.

11 Parks & Public Spaces

26 complaints · 2.9% of all complaints

“Every Park Playable”

Resident: “The playground is rusted which is a hazard... unpainted basketball court, broken glass on the courts.”

Term	Policy
SHORT	Safety sweep of every playground Inspect all equipment, publish the findings, and fix or close what is hazardous - residents named rusted equipment and glass on courts specifically.
SHORT	A published maintenance standard Set mowing, litter and court-resurfacing frequencies and report against them park by park.
SHORT	Report-a-problem code on every park sign A scannable code that files a tracked case, so a broken swing does not depend on knowing whom to call.
LONG	A rolling renovation programme worst-first Rank every park by condition and renovate on a published cycle, starting with the smaller neighbourhood parks that residents say are skipped.
LONG	Equity test on parks capital spending Publish investment per resident by neighbourhood, so waterfront showpieces cannot crowd out the parks people use daily.

12 Homelessness & Quality of Life

22 complaints · 2.5% of all complaints

“A Door for Everyone”

Resident: “We have over 800 homeless men and women here in Yonkers.”

Term	Policy
SHORT	Street outreach with a placement, not a move-along Teams that can offer a bed and a caseworker the same day.
SHORT	Enforce the noise rules people actually raise Set and enforce hours for leaf blowers and amplified sound, with a complaint route that produces a response.
SHORT	Public bathrooms and water in the busy parks Basic facilities remove a recurring quality-of-life flashpoint for everyone using the space.
LONG	Permanent supportive housing Housing paired with services is what ends chronic homelessness; shelter capacity alone recycles people through the system.
LONG	Homelessness prevention fund Emergency rent and arrears help, which is far cheaper than sheltering a family after eviction.

13 Street Lighting & Infrastructure

16 complaints · 1.8% of all complaints

“Light Every Corner”

Resident: “Street lights should be fixed so they actually work. Also install new ones where there aren’t, like Agar St.”

Term	Policy
SHORT	Seven-day streetlight repair A published deadline from report to relight, with outages mapped publicly so nobody wonders if it was logged.
SHORT	Night audit of the dark blocks Walk the streets residents name after dark, and fill the gaps where no light was ever installed.
SHORT	Clear the sight lines Trim vegetation blocking lights and signs, and enforce against trucks parked where they block crossings and visibility.
LONG	City-wide LED conversion with smart outage reporting Fixtures that report their own failures, so repairs start before a resident has to complain.
LONG	Lighting standards in every capital project Fold pedestrian-scale lighting into paving, park and streetscape work rather than treating it as a separate ask.

14 Traffic, Speeding & Reckless Driving

9 complaints · 1.0% of all complaints

“Slow the Streets Down”

Resident: “Drivers always going through red lights, passing buses... drag racing... riding on the sidewalks.”

Term	Policy
SHORT	Daylight the dangerous corners Clear parking back from crossings at the intersections residents name, so drivers and pedestrians can see each other.
SHORT	Traffic calming where schools and crossings are Speed humps, raised crossings and signal timing prioritised around schools and bus stops.
SHORT	Target the dirt bikes and ATVs at the source Enforcement aimed at the sale, storage and fuelling of illegal off-road vehicles rather than street pursuits.
LONG	Redesign the arterials residents keep naming Road diets, protected crossings and median refuges on the corridors where speeding is chronic.
LONG	A published Vision Zero plan with a crash map Rank every intersection by injury history and fix them in order, reporting progress annually.